

On 19 September 2025 the National Management Group (NMG) agreed with advice from the Consultative Committee on Emergency Plant Pests that potato mop-top virus (PMTV) is not technically feasible to eradicate from Australia.

This decision reflects several challenges:

- Difficulty detecting all infected areas
- The virus's ability to persist undetected in soil
- Widespread presence of powdery scab (a known vector)
- Risk of spread via seed, tubers, and soil movement

In the coming weeks, the NMG will consider options under the Emergency Plant Pest Response Deed to support Tasmanian potato growers with financial losses and costs incurred.

PMTV affects developing potato plants and is transmitted by a common soil-borne pathogen found in Tasmania and mainland Australia that causes powdery scab. The virus can reduce potato quality by causing skin distortions, cracking, and discoloration of the flesh, and may impact crop yields in some varieties.

Importantly, there are no human health or food safety risks associated with PMTV or powdery scab. All potatoes remain safe to eat.

Biosecurity Tasmania is working closely with affected growers and potato industry bodies to conduct additional surveillance and diagnostics of potato seed stock. These efforts aim to better understand the distribution of PMTV and manage the risk of further spread.

If you suspect the presence of an exotic plant pest, contact the Exotic Plant Pest Hotline on 1800 084 881. You can find out more about how we respond to plant pest and disease incidents at www.outbreak.gov.au.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/potato-mop-top-19sep2025>